

Original Prompt

Help me write a sci-fi short story about a 4 man crew aboard a delivery space ship that specializes in extremely valuable deliveries. Make it a thriller story, a corporate repo fleet catches up to the Starlight Courier mid-transit and they are carrying a crate that contains the most valuable substance in time, liquid common sense, reserved for only the richest and most powerful. They are trying to smuggle it out of a restrictive warzone back to their home planet to further advance problem solving and become the richest planet in the galaxy.

Bonji, the captain, is stoic but secretly has stress a lot, always worrying about the ship and crew. His motivation is because he inherited the ship from his family and is deeply in debt and his goal is to complete this almost impossible delivery. Bonji can feel subtle vibrations in the ship's hull before the sensors even detect a system failure or an incoming hazard and Obsessively polishes a brass antique compass passed down from the ship's original owner whenever tense situations arise.

Neb Jr the 3rd is a hyper-active fast-talking engineer and tech genius with a goal of secretly making an advanced black-market warp-drive modification using spare parts. His motivation is to leave the mundane delivery sector and joining an elite outer rim exploration team that requires a customized high-speed vessel and is easily bored with routine maintenance. He Drinks absurdly potent alien energy drinks out of a cracked measuring beaker. Names every tool in their workshop and gets genuinely offended if someone calls a wrench by its real name instead of "Buster."

Stivio is the cargo specialist and a new recruit who is earnest, hyper-vigilant, and slightly paranoid. He always checking the lock readouts, terrified that a single drop of their precious cargo might leak or get discovered. Stivio can look at any cargo bay or container and instantly calculate the exact maximum weight capacity and optimal stacking arrangement down to the millimeter. Refers to the "liquid common sense" crate using bizarre code names like "Project Grandmama's Soup" whenever anyone is nearby. He also Wears heavily padded, multi-pocketed work vests and refuses to sit down unless they know every emergency exit in the room.

KanRita is the Navigator and an ex-cartographer who is quiet, methodical, and intense. KanRita speaks in soft, precise tones and prefers staring at star maps rather than making small talk with the rest of the crew. KanRita can memorize and mentally simulate complex, multi-dimensional stellar drift patterns without needing a flight computer overlay. She paces around the bridge in rhythmic, counting steps whenever calculating jump vectors and collects physical glass slides of

ancient, hand-drawn star charts and projects them onto the ceiling of their quarters before sleeping. Chart a newly discovered shortcut through an unstable nebula during their delivery route. Her motivation is looking for a legacy and redemption after their former navigational mistake caused an expedition to get stranded years ago. Her main goal is to chart a newly discovered shortcut through an unstable nebula during their delivery route.

Response from ChatGPT

Your prompt already has one major strength: **excellent character design**. Each crew member has a distinct personality, motivation, quirk, and special skill. That's the kind of information that helps an AI generate memorable characters instead of generic ones.

Where your prompt can improve is by giving the AI **stronger structural guidance**. Right now it has fantastic ingredients, but no blueprint for how to assemble them.

Here are the biggest improvements I'd make.

1. Define the tone

Instead of simply saying "thriller," describe the feeling you're after.

For example:

Write in the style of a tense, cinematic science-fiction thriller. Blend the suspense of *Alien*, the blue-collar realism of *The Expanse*, the found-family dynamic of *Firefly*, and the escalating paranoia of *Andor*. Keep the technology believable and avoid space fantasy.

That gives the AI a much clearer target.

2. Give the ship personality

Right now the crew is detailed, but the ship is almost a blank slate.

Something like:

The Starlight Courier is an aging medium-sized cargo vessel held together with decades of repairs. Every corridor rattles, every bulkhead groans under stress, and every system has been modified so many times that no two circuits follow the original schematics. Despite its age, the ship has never failed a delivery.

Now the setting becomes another character.

3. Raise the stakes

Instead of saying they're carrying something valuable, explain *why* it's so important.

For example:

Liquid Common Sense is an engineered neurofluid capable of temporarily increasing logical reasoning, emotional regulation, and long-term planning. It is so transformative that governments classify it as a strategic resource. Entire wars have been fought over a few liters.

That instantly makes readers think:

"Oh...that's dangerous."

4. Make the antagonists interesting

Instead of

a corporate repo fleet

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expand it.

Example:

The pursuing fleet belongs to Meridian Asset Recovery, a ruthless corporate reclamation company legally empowered to seize ships whose owners default on debt. Publicly they are accountants with guns; privately they are feared bounty hunters who leave no witnesses.

Now they're memorable.

5. Add internal conflict

Currently everyone is working toward the same goal.

A better thriller happens when everyone also wants something different.

Example:

- Bonji wants to save the family ship.
- Neb secretly wants to steal technology from the cargo.
- Stivio wonders if they should turn themselves in.
- KanRita believes the shortcut will destroy the ship.

Now every decision creates drama.

6. Explain the mystery

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The phrase "Liquid Common Sense" is fantastic because it's weird.

Don't explain everything immediately.

Instead:

The true origin of Liquid Common Sense should remain mysterious for most of the story. Characters know what it does, but nobody fully understands who invented it or why only a handful of civilizations possess it.

Mystery is fuel for thrillers.

7. Give the AI a story structure

This is probably the biggest improvement.

Something like:

Follow a three-act structure.

Act I

- Introduce the crew during a routine delivery.
- Reveal the impossible cargo.
- Show hints they are being followed.

Act II

- The corporate fleet intercepts them.

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- The crew discovers someone leaked their route.
- Systems begin mysteriously failing.
- Trust inside the crew starts breaking down.

Act III

- A desperate chase through the unstable nebula.
- A moral dilemma involving the cargo.
- An ending that resolves the mission while leaving one major mystery unanswered.

Now the AI knows where the story is going.

8. Specify pacing

Otherwise AI often rushes.

Example:

Build tension slowly. Allow quiet character moments between action scenes. Every chapter should either reveal new information, deepen a relationship, or increase danger.

9. Add recurring motifs

Great stories repeat symbols.

For example:

- Bonji constantly polishing the compass.
- Neb drinking stronger and stranger energy drinks.
- KanRita counting under her breath.
- Stivio inventing increasingly ridiculous code names.

Those habits become recognizable signatures.

10. Give the AI "don't do this" rules

This is surprisingly effective.

For example:

Avoid clichés such as:

- "chosen one"
 - secret royalty
 - deus ex machina rescues
 - evil AI taking over
 - convenient coincidences
 - characters surviving impossible situations without consequences
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I'd also add worldbuilding

Things like:

- What currency does the galaxy use?
- How does faster-than-light travel work?
- Who controls trade?
- What ended the last war?
- Why is Liquid Common Sense illegal?
- How expensive is this shipment compared to an ordinary cargo?
- What does daily life look like aboard a delivery ship?

These little details make the world feel lived in.

One feature I'd absolutely add

Your crew already has distinct personalities, but they need chemistry.

For example:

- Bonji treats Neb like an irresponsible younger sibling.
- Neb constantly teases Stivio.
- Stivio trusts KanRita more than anyone.

- KanRita quietly respects Bonji but never says so.

Those relationship dynamics will make conversations feel natural instead of four people taking turns speaking.

Overall

I'd rate your current prompt **8.5/10**. The characters are the standout feature—they're specific, quirky, and motivated. The biggest opportunity is to add more guidance about the world, the antagonists, the story structure, and the relationships between the crew. With those additions, this could easily become a **9.8–10/10** prompt that consistently produces a tense, character-driven sci-fi thriller rather than just an interesting premise.